



Game Rules 1.0

Constructing a Deck

Note: Playing with the entire faction starter deck to begin with is fine if you want to skip this step until you become more familiar with the cards.

To build a deck for *Goon Squad Galaxy*, you start by choosing which faction you want to play — either **NARC** or **PCU**. You can't mix cards between the two, so everything in your deck has to match the faction you've chosen.

From there, you're aiming to build a 52-card deck. It is okay to have more than 52 cards. Within that, you can include up to four copies of any single card — except for **Titans**, which are limited to one copy per deck. You'll also only have one **Squad Leader**, and that card starts on the field at the beginning of the game, so you don't need to worry about drawing or deploying it.

When selecting your cards, you want to balance your Goons across different ranks — some **Basic Goons** to help cover the field early, some **Squad Goons** with stronger effects, and maybe a **Titan** for a high-impact play later. Make sure you're paying attention to each card's deploy cost so you don't load your deck with cards that are too expensive to get into play reliably. You'll also want to keep an eye on synergy — for example, some cards require other specific Goons to already be in play or combo well when used together.

Once you've selected your cards — following all those restrictions — that's your legal deck. No sideboard, no extra cards. You're ready to play.

Playing the Game

To start a game of *Goon Squad Galaxy*, each player brings their own pre-constructed deck, built entirely from one faction — either **NARC** or **PCU**. You and your opponent sit across from each other, shuffle your decks thoroughly, and draw your 6-card opening hands.

Each player places their **Squad Leader** on the field immediately — no cost, no delay. It always starts in play and is never drawn or deployed. It anchors your board and is the only card that begins face-up, ready to act (though remember, you still can't use abilities the turn a Goon enters, even **Squad Leaders**).

You can't target a **Squad Leader** (SL) with any hostile effect — like an ability that adds wind or destroys — as long as the player controls any other Goons. That includes **Basic Goons** (BGs) or **Squad Goons** (SGs).

So, for example, if a player has Grim (an SL) on the field, and also a Void Freak (a BG), your Buzzkill cannot use BLAST to hit Grim. The presence of that BG (or any SG) makes the SL untargetable. You'd have to destroy all of that player's other Goons first — then the **Squad Leader** becomes a legal target.

This is called the protection hierarchy, and it's a key tactical layer in GSG — you have to grind through the squad before you can go for the throat.

You decide who goes first — coin flip, roll, however you prefer. Then, the game begins with the first player's turn: draw a card, unwind any winded Goons, and proceed through the phases. Players alternate turns from that point forward, deploying Goons by winding those already in play to pay costs, using abilities, and trying to outlast or outmaneuver each other.

Once cards start hitting the field, the dance of wind, unwinding, targeting, and tactical deployment begins.

A player turn is made of a Draw phase, Unwind phase, Deploy phase and Action phase.

Draw Phase

At the very beginning of your turn in Goon Squad Galaxy, before you do anything else, you draw a card from your deck. This is called the **Draw Phase**, and it happens before any other part of your turn unfolds. That fresh card joins your hand, which can be any size — there's no hand limit.

Unwind Phase

After you draw your card, the **second phase** of your turn begins — the Unwind Phase. This is when your Goons recover slightly from damage or strain they've taken in previous turns.

Every Goon you control that doesn't have the no unwind icon  will unwind 1 wind. This means you rotate their card 90 degrees clockwise, easing the rotation back toward an upright, zero-wind state. The closer they are to zero wind, the more ready and resilient they are — a fully unwound Goon is at full strength.

If a Goon has 3 wind, for example, and isn't blocked from unwinding, you rotate it once clockwise — now it has only 2 wind. It's still wounded, but recovering.

Deploy Phase

The **third phase** of your turn in Goon Squad Galaxy is the **Deploy Phase**, and this is where you bring new Goons onto the battlefield.

At this point, you look at your hand and decide if you want to deploy any cards. Each Goon in your hand has a deploy cost printed on the card — usually at the top of the icon column on the left side of the card — and that cost is paid using wind from Goons that are already in play or have been sent to the Dead Pool. If a card costs 3 wind to deploy, you'll need to add 3 wind to your Goons in play, distributed however you choose, to satisfy that cost.



You're overworking your Goons, pushing them closer to destruction by adding wind to them. Wind is tracked by rotating the cards 90 degrees counter-clockwise for each wind added. If you push a Goon too far — up to 4 wind — it dies.

It's also worth noting that some cards have additional requirements to be deployed — like needing another specific card already in play. Those must also be met in this phase.

Finally, when you deploy a Goon, it enters the field fresh, with zero wind. It can't act this turn, but it's there, ready to help on your next one. Once you've deployed whatever you want — or can afford — you move on.

Action Phase

The **fourth phase** of a Goon Squad Galaxy turn is the Action Phase, and this is where most of the real gameplay happens. This is when you activate the abilities on your Goons, target enemies, and manipulate the board.

During this phase, you can use abilities from any of your Goons that have been in play since the start of your turn. Newly deployed Goons can't act yet — they're still getting their bearings, so to speak. Goons often have multiple abilities but they are permitted to use only one per turn. Each ability on a card has a cost associated with it, usually paid by adding wind to the Goon.



Using a Goon's ability means you declare which you're activating, name the target if it has one, and then pay the cost. Most abilities cost wind — which is to say, the Goon spends its own energy by accumulating wind. Other Goons can't contribute wind to help pay for an ability. The Goon must pay for its own ability activation cost. Some abilities also require biological  or mechanical  resources from the **dead pool** as an activation cost. Once the cost is paid, you resolve the ability as written on the card. Some abilities don't cost wind or resources to activate but they still count towards the single ability Goon is permitted to use per turn. No cost abilities are not to be confused with **passive** abilities which are always in effect. **Passive**  abilities don't need to be activated in this phase — they're always on and don't count against the once-per-turn rule. All other abilities must go through this phase to be used.

Targeting is precise: you can only hit legal targets. You can't target a **Squad Leader (SL)** with any hostile effect — like an ability that adds wind or destroys — as long as the player controls any other Goons. That includes **Basic Goons (BGs)** or **Squad Goons (SGs)**.

So, for example, if a player has Grim (an SL) on the field, and also a Void Freak (a BG), your Buzzkill cannot use BLAST to hit Grim. The presence of that BG (or any SG) makes the SL untargetable. You'd have to destroy all of that player's other Goons first — then the **Squad Leader** becomes a legal target.

This is called the protection hierarchy, and it's a key tactical layer in GSG — you have to grind through the squad before you can go for the throat.

Once you've used all the abilities you want to — or are able to — you're done with the **Action Phase**, and the turn proceeds to the end.

The Wind System

Note: "wind" is pronounced like "grind"

In *Goon Squad Galaxy*, the wind system is the central mechanic for tracking both damage and resource expenditure on your Goons. Every time a Goon pays wind — whether to use an ability or to help deploy another card — it accumulates wind, which brings it closer to destruction. Your opponent's Goons will also target your Goons with abilities to add wind as damage to your Goons. This is how Goons attack one another. If a Goon reaches four wind the Goon is destroyed.

To track how much wind your Goons have accumulated, there is a simple but elegant physical method: **rotating** or **"winding up"** the card. The rotation forms a clear visual health counter. Anyone looking at the table can immediately tell how close each Goon is to death, just from the angle of the card.

Here's how it works:



Cards enter play in their natural upright orientation. They are fresh, healthy and haven't accumulated any wind.



Every time a Goon accumulates wind, you rotate or "wind" the card 90 degrees counter-clockwise. At 1 wind the Goon card's position is sideways and its top faces left.



From there accumulating another wind rotates the card counter-clockwise again and it is now upside-down. A Goon in this position has accumulated 2 wind



The next point of wind rotates the card again so its top is on the right side. The Goon is at 3 wind now and is maxed out on the wind it can tolerate



The next time the Goon is wound it *would* be in the upright position but it has had all of the stress it can take. It's at 4 wind, is destroyed and sent to the **Dead Pool**. The **Dead Pool** is a mutual discard pile shared by all players.

We know how Goons wind up but they also unwind. At the start of each of your turns, during the **Unwind Phase**, all of your Goons **unwind 1** (unless they have the **no unwind** icon 🚫). This means you **rotate them 90 degrees clockwise**, pulling them back toward the upright, zero-wind position. It represents them recovering slightly — catching their breath, so to speak.

Spending wind which results in a Goon accumulating 4 wind and destroying itself is a legal move. Any deploy or abilities paid for with the wind resulting in destruction resolve before Goon is destroyed. In certain situations sacrificing a Goon to make a critical play may be a strategically sound move

The Dead Pool

The **Dead Pool** represents the fallen bodies on the battlefield — the wreckage and remains of Goons that have been destroyed. The **Dead Pool** is a kind of tactical graveyard — not just a resting place, but a fuel source made of corpses and wreckage. It's not private. It's a shared, open resource that both players can access. It is composed of **all players'** destroyed Goons. Yes, that means your opponent can use your dead Goons for resources in addition to their destroyed Goons. And you may use both also. So all Players' discard piles need to be accessible for other players to rummage through.



Some Goons deploy or ability requirements may include resources from the **Dead Pool**.

There are 2 types of resources, Biological and Mechanical. To meet a biological resource requirement, find a Goon in the Dead Pool with the 🩸 icon and **"Burn"** it. Burning simply means removing the card from the game entirely. **Burned** Goons are returned to the owner to place in an out-of-game card stack. If a deploy or ability cost has a mechanical resource requirement, find a Goon in the Dead Pool with the ⚙️ icon and **Burn** it.

Goon Card Anatomy

Goon Squad Galaxy cards are designed to display card information while cards are held as a hand. The icons on the left edge of the cards give a summary of the cards characteristics. Cost for deploying the card is listed on top as that will be the first step in bringing the card into play. Then property icons relating to using the card in active play. These include Goon rank, innate defences and limitations . Next the Goon's biological or mechanical identifier icons. Last is the faction icon.



Deploy Costs and Property Icons

TODO - text to explain what the icons are



Wind Cost - Cost in wind to deploy the Goon. The circular arrow indicates the resource to pay for deployment is wind. X represents the amount of wind required. For deployment, wind may be contributed by any goon in play other than ones deployed this turn.



Mechanical Cost - Cost in Mechanical to deploy the Goon. The gear indicates the resource to pay for deployment is Mechanical. X represents the amount of Mechanical. Mechanical resources may be found in the **Dead Pool**. A destroyed Goon, with the  icon, in the **Dead Pool**, can be **Burned** (removed from game) to pay 1 Mechanical Cost. Subsequent Goons from the Dead Pool may be Burned also if needed for additional costs.



Biological Cost - Biological cost to deploy the Goon. The blood indicates the resource to pay for deployment is Biological. X represents the amount of Biological. Biological resources may be found in the **Dead Pool**. A destroyed Goon, with the  icon, in the **Dead Pool**, can be **Burned** (removed from game) to pay 1 Biological cost. Subsequent Goons from the Dead Pool may be Burned also if needed for additional costs.



Resist - When wind added to Goon from by enemy Goon ability effect, total wind added is reduced by 1. For example, if 1 wind is applied as an attack from hostile Goon ability the damage is resisted and has no effect. If two wind are applied as an attack from hostile Goon ability, wind from damage is reduced to one. And so forth.



Does not unwind - Goon does not unwind during the unwind phase. It may still be unwound by other means - ability effects.



Goon is **biological** in nature and can be **Burned** from the **Dead Pool** to produce biological resource to pay deployment or ability costs



Goon is **mechanical** in nature and can be **Burned** from the **Dead Pool** to produce mechanical resource to pay deployment or ability costs



Faction Symbol for Population Control Unit Goons



Faction Symbol for NARC Squad Goons



Goon Type - Squad Leader(SL) - Squad Leader is unique and begins the game in play. SL may not be the target of hostile Goon abilities when Squad Goons or Basic Goons are in play. Player loses if SL destroyed



Goon Type - Squad Goon(SG) - Player may have up to 4 duplicates of a SG in deck but only 1 may be in play at a time



Goon Type - Basic Goons(BG) don't have a type icon. 4 duplicates of BG Goons are allowed in a deck and any number of BGs can be in play simultaneously.



Goon Type - Titan(T) - Titan is unique. Only 1 may be present in a legal deck. Titan is invulnerable and may not be targeted. Titan does not protect SL from being targeted and may not contribute wind to deploy Goons. Titan pays its ability costs the same as other Goons and is destroyed if wind reaches 4 like other Goons. Titans do not go to the dead pool when destroyed. They are **Burned** and removed from the game.



Name

Entire name. Sometimes shortened in ability text

Portrait

Artwork section

Abilities

Abilities can be attacks that increase the wind of enemy Goons, benefit friendly Goons or any number of effects. Ability use is described in detail in previous sections.

An off white circle icon containing a number  indicates the **wind cost** the Goon must pay to activate ability.  indicates a variable amount may be paid to activate the ability.

If an ability costs no wind to activate it will have  as the wind cost. The single ability use per turn rule still applies.

A grey circle icon containing a number  indicates the **mechanical** resource cost pulled from the dead pool (dead Goons with the  icon).  indicates a variable amount may be paid to activate the ability.

A red circle icon containing a number  indicates the **biological** resource cost pulled from the dead pool (dead Goons with the  icon).  indicates a variable amount may be paid to activate the ability.

Passive ability name and description are preceded with an infinity icon . Again, passive abilities are always active.

Flavor Text

Lore or background information about the Goon. Purely cosmetic and does not affect game play

Glossary

Ability

A special skill or power that a character or unit can use during the game. Most abilities are used on the player's turn. Passive abilities are always in effect.

Activate

To trigger or initiate an ability or effect.

Active

A state in which a character or unit is able to use abilities and contribute wind in an action or effect.

Allied

Refers to goons that belong to the same player

Basic Goon

A standard or common unit with no special abilities.

Biological

Describes goons that are organic in nature. Goon can be burned from the dead pool as resources

BG

Basic Goon

Burn

Card is permanently removed from game

Contribute

To add or provide some or all wind to deploy a Goon from player's hand

Cost

The resources or conditions required to use an ability or deploy a unit.

Damage

Wind applied to a Goon as the result of being targeted with opponent's Goon ability

Dead

Synonymous with "destroyed". Goon is moved to Dead Pool and becomes a mechanical or biological resource if it has the corresponding icon for either.

Dead Pool

Collection of all Goons belonging to all players that have been destroyed

Deck

A collection of cards or units that a player uses during the game. The cards within must belong to the same faction

Deploy

To place a unit or card into play by paying deploy costs from GOon wind contributions or resources from the dead pool

Destroy

To remove a character or unit from play, typically through damage or effects. Destroyed Goons typically go to the dead pool

Faction

The Collection of Goons that may be present in a deck. NARC or PCU

Flavor Text

Descriptive or thematic text that provides background or context, not affecting gameplay.

Friendly

Refers to Goons that are on the player's team.

Goon

All cards are considered goons

Hostile

Refers to characters or units on the opposing team. Enemy goons are adversaries. The abilities they use to harm your goons are antagonistic.

Mechanical

Refers to units or effects that are machine-based or non-organic. They may be used to fulfil A goon deploy requirement or to activate an ability

NARC

A specific faction or group within the game. Short for NARC Squad

NARC Squad

Full name of the NARC faction.

No Unwind

A condition or effect that prevents a goon from unwinding during the unwind phase of players turn.

Passive Ability

An ability that is always in effect without needing to be activated.

PCU

Acronym for Population Control Unit faction.

Player

A participant in the game controlling a deck and the Goons within

Population Control Unit

Full name of PCU faction

Protect

The effect which makes Squad Leader immune to enemy goon ability effects

Rank

Squad Leader, Squad Goon, Basic Goon and Titan. May also be stated as goon type

Resist

A goon with resist is able to offset some wind applied as damage from hostile enemy goon abilities. When wind added to Goon from by enemy Goon ability effect, total wind added is reduced by 1. For example, if 1 wind is applied as an attack from hostile Goon ability the damage is resisted and has no effect. If 2 wind are applied as an attack from hostile Goon ability, wind from damage is reduced to one. And so forth.

SG

Squad Goon

SL

Squad Leader

Squad Goon

More powerful Goon. Only 1 Goon of a SG type may be in play at a time within the player's deploy goons. E.g. A player may not have 2 Killjoys or 2 Vexes in play at the same time. Up to 4 duplicates are allowed in your deck but must remain undeployed until the active identical goon card is destroyed.

Squad Leader

Squad Leader is unique and begins the game in play. SL may not be the target of hostile Goon abilities when allied Squad or Basic Goons are in play. Player loses game if their SL destroyed

T

Titan.

Titan

Titan is unique. Only 1 may be present in a legal deck. Titan is invulnerable and may not be targeted by goon abilities belonging to any player. Titan does not protect SL from being targeted and may not contribute wind to deploy Goons. Titan pays its ability costs the same as other Goons and is destroyed if its wind reaches 4 like other Goons. Titans do not go to the **dead pool** when destroyed. They are burned and removed from the game.

Turn

A player's opportunity to perform their action in the game.

Unwind

Goons recover slightly from damage or strain they've taken in previous turns. To remove wind, rotate their card 90 degrees clockwise. Most often this happens during the player's unwind phase when goons are unwound 1. When the card reaches an upright, zero-wind state. The goon is fully unwound and at full strength

Wind

A goon pays wind to use an ability or to help deploy another card — it accumulates wind, which brings it closer to destruction. Your opponents also target your goons with abilities to increase your goons' wind. 4 wind means the Goon is destroyed. Rotate or “wind” the card 90 degrees counter-clockwise when it accumulates a wind to track its wind.